Lewis (Kuizhi) Wang

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Areas of Specialization

History of Modern Philosophy (esp. Kant and Hegel), Buddhist Philosophy, Epistemology

Areas of Competence

Aesthetics, Philosophy of Language, Ethics, Political Philosophy, Chinese Philosophy

Employment

2026 - 2027	**University of Texas at El Paso** Visiting Assistant Professor in Philosophy

Education

2019 - 2026	**Boston University** Ph.D. in Philosophy *Dissertation*: Towards A Hybrid Reading of Kant's Transcendental Idealism *Advisor*: Sally Sedgwick
Sept 2024 - Feb 2025	**Goethe University Frankfurt** Visiting Student *Host*: Marcus Willaschek
2023 - 2024	**Princeton University, Princeton Project in Philosophy & Religion** Visiting Student Research Collaborator *Host*: Andrew Chignell
2017 – 2019	**University of Oxford** BPhil in Philosophy
2013 – 2017	**University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign** B.A. in Philosophy and Economics, *Magna Cum Laude*

Publications

Journal Articles

forthcoming	"A Buddhist Case for Ontological Idealism: Two Arguments Against Mind-Independent Existence in Xuanzang's *Cheng Weishi Lun*", *Ergo*
forthcoming	"Susan Sontag and Our Duties Towards Photographs of Violence and Suffering", *The Journal of Ethics*
2025	"On the Epistemic Instrumentalist Solution to the Combinatorial Problem", *Synthese* 205 (218): 1-15.
2024	"The Early Development of Kant's Practical Notion of Belief", *Inquiry*, 1-18.
2023	"Kant on Propositional Content and Knowledge", *Kant Yearbook* 15 (1): 175-196.

Book Chapters

forthcoming	"Hegelian Sufficientarianism and Limitarianism as an Anti-Colonial Theory of Justice" (with Joshua Folkerts), in Bernardo Ferro and Paul Giladi (eds.), *Hegel's Philosophy of Emancipation*. London: Routledge.
forthcoming	"On the Secondary Quality Analogy", in Christoph Horn, Margit Ruffing and Rainer Schäfer (eds), *Proceedings of the 14th International Kant Congress: Kant's Project of Enlightenment*. Berlin: De Gruyter
2025	"Hegel's Justification of Private Property", in Andrew A. Davis and Sebastian Rand (eds.), *New Perspectives on Hegel's Philosophy of Right*, London: Bloomsbury, 37-55.

Book Reviews

forthcoming	Review of Paul Morrow, *Seeing Atrocities: Ethics for Visual Encounters with Intolerable Harms*, *Journal of Applied Philosophy*
forthcoming	Review of Till Hoeppner, *Urteil und Anschauung: Kants metaphysische Deduktion der Kategorien*, *Studi Kantiani* 39: 151-154
2026	Review of Gabriele Gava, *Kant's Critique of Pure Reason and the Method of Metaphysics*, *British Journal for the History of Philosophy* 34 (1): 182-187.

Works in Progress

Under review	A paper on Kant's doctrine of Noumenal Ignorance
In Progress	"Kant's Method of Metaphysics"
In progress	"Kant on Reasons for Belief" (with Marcus Willaschek)
In progress	"Kant on the Inescapability of the Human Standpoint and the Limit of Metaphysics"
In progress	"Hegel's Implicit Solution to the Problem of Poverty"
In progress	"Argument from Ignorance and Dharmakīrti's Epistemological Pragmatism"
In progress	"Kant's Theory of Meaning" (with Davide Dalla Rosa)
In progress	"Kant on *Sinn* and *Bedeutung*" (with Christopher Benzenberg)
Invited	"Dharmottara's Theory of Propositional Content"(*Philosophical Topics*)
Invited	Comments on Stefanie Grüne's "Kant on the Relation Between Cognition and Knowledge"

Awards, Grants, and Fellowships

Spring 2025	Bloom Dissertation Fellowship, Boston University
Fall 2025	Dissertation Fellowship, Boston University Center for the Humanities
2024 – 2025	Graduate Research Abroad Fellowship, Boston University
2023, 2025	Professional Development GrantFund Award (for Kant on Language and Cognition Workshop), Boston University
2024	The Helen G. Allen Humanities Award and the Angela J. and James J. Rallis Memorial Award, Boston University Center for the Humanities ($5500)
2023	Professional Development Grant (for CCEC summer program), Boston University
2021	Graduate Student Organization Travel Grant, Boston University
2021	Summer Research Fellowship, Boston University

2021	Stipendium für Hochschulsommerkurse in Deutschland (Grant for Summer Language Course in Germany), DAAD (German Academic Exchange Service)
2019 – 2020	Dean's Fellowship, Boston University
2019	Irene H. Chayes Travel Grant, American Society of Aesthetics
2017	Brian Keelan Award in Humanities, China Oxford Scholarship Fund (£7000)
2017	Honorable Mention for Best Undergraduate Student Research, Illinois Program of Research in Humanities Prizes, UIUC
2017	Highest Distinction in Philosophy, UIUC
2016	Lois Shepard Green Award, Department of Philosophy, UIUC
2015	Howard F. Crombie Award, Department of Philosophy, UIUC

Teaching Experience

University of Texas at El Paso

- PHIL 1301: Introduction to Philosophy (Topic: Ancient Wisdom on A Good Life): Fall 2026 (x2)
- PHIL 3325: Social Philosophy: Fall 2026

Boston University

- PH 100: Introduction to Philosophy (Topic: Life and Death): Summer 2024
- PH 310: History of Modern Philosophy: Summer 2022

Selected Presentations

(* = refereed; ˆ= invited)

"Hegel's Theory of Distributive Justice" (with Joshua Folkerts)

Nov 2026	Society for German Idealism and Romanticism Annual Conference, Boston University*

"Arguments from Ignorance and Buddhist Epistemological Pragmatism"

Sept 2026	3CPR Conference, University of Notre Dame*

"Kant's Theory of Meaning" (with Davide Dalla Rosa)

May 2026	NYC Workshop in Early Modern Philosophy, Fordham University*
Nov 2025	Frankfurter Kant-Arbeitskreis, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt
Feb 2025	Kant on Language and Cognition Workshop, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt

"Kant on the Inescapability of the Human Standpoint and the Limit of Metaphysics"

Apr 2026	The International Kant Colloquiumˆ
Mar 2026	Metaphysical Society of America Annual Meeting*

"Can We Know the Existence of Things in Themselves, Prof. Kant?"

Feb 2026	American Philosophical Association (APA) Central Division Meeting, Chicago*
Jan 2025	Frankfurter Kant-Arbeitskreis, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt
Sep 2022	UK Kant Society Conference, London*

"Kant on Reasons for Belief" (with Marcus Willaschek)

Feb 2026	SGIR Session "Kant's Ethics of Belief", APA Central Division Meeting, Chicago
Oct 2025	Thinking with Assent: Belief and Ethics of Belief between History and Theory, Collegio Ghislieri, Pavia^

"Kant on *Sinn* and *Bedeutung*" (with Christopher Benzenberg)

Jul 2025	Kant Work in Progress Workshop, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt

"Xuanzang's Master Argument Against Mind-Independent Existence in *Cheng Weishi Lun*"

Jul 2025	Society for Asian and Comparative Philosophy Annual Conference, Leiden University*

"Hegel and the Problem of Poverty"

Mar 2025	Graduate Students Work in Progress Workshop, Boston University
Apr 2022	British Society for the History of Philosophy Annual Conference*
Apr 2022	APA Pacific Division Meeting, Vancouver*
Nov 2021	Oxford Graduate Philosophy Conference, Online*

"Kant's Theory of Reasons for Belief"

Feb 2025	California Polytechnic State University
Jan 2025	Belief in Kant Workshop, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt^
Dec 2024	Orientation and Disorientation: Kantian Themes in Analytic Philosophy, Reggio-Emilia*
Apr 2024	Princeton Project in Philosophy and Religion Working Group, Princeton University

"On the Secondary Quality Analogy"

Sep 2024	14th International Kant Congress, Bonn*
Feb 2024	APA Central Division Meeting, New Orleans*

"Hegelian Sufficientarianism as an Anti-Colonial Theory of Justice" (with Joshua Folkerts)

Aug 2024	Emancipation in Hegel's Metaphysics and Social Theory Conference, School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London*

"The Role and Significance of the Doctrine of Method"

May 2024	North American Kant Society South Study Group Meeting, Columbia, SC*
Dec 2022	Kant Graduate Student Forum, Harvard University^

"Against the Epistemic Instrumentalist Solution to the Combinatorial Problem"

Jan 2024	APA Eastern Division Meeting, New York*

"Susan Sontag and the Moral Impact of Photographs of Violence and Suffering"

Nov 2023	American Society of Aesthetics Annual Meeting, Washington D.C.*
Aug 2023	Rocky Mountain Ethics Congress, Boulder, CO*
Jun 2021	European Society of Aesthetics Conference, Online*

"Hegel's Developmental Justification of Private Property"

Oct 2022	Biennial Conference of the Hegel Society of America, Nashville*
Jun 2021	33rd International Hegel Congress, Online*

"On the Location of Kant's Refutation of Idealism"

Jan 2020	APA Eastern Division Meeting, Philadelphia*
Nov 2018	Kant Colloquium, University of Oxford

"No Duties of Global Distributive Justice: A Kantian Theory"

Jun 2018	Brave New World Graduate Conference, University of Manchester*
Jun 2018	Kant's Legal Theory and Global Justice Conference, University of Bayreuth*
Mar 2018	Graduate Conference at University of Tennessee Knoxville*

Professional Comments

Jan 2026	Comments on Shruta Swarup, "The Motive of Duty, Emotional Motives, and the Kantian Criterion of Summonability", APA Eastern Division Meeting, Baltimore
Jan 2025	Comments on Bangrui Chen, "Kant, Apperception, and the Unity of Cognition", APA Eastern Division Meeting, New York
Dec 2024	Comments on Stefanie Grüne, "Kant on the Relation between Cognition and Knowledge", the Annual Jean-Jacques Rousseau Conference, ECPR Standing Group on Kantian Political Thought, Colchester, UK
May 2023	Comments on Samantha Matherne, "Beauty and the Life of the Mind in Kant and Hegel", "Organism and Life: Herder, Kant, Hegel" Workshop, Boston University

Academic Service

2025 -	Referee for *Nous*, *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, *Kantian Review* (x2)
May 2026	Co-Organizer (with Jens Timmermann and Giampiero Basile), Boston-Area Kant Colloquium, Boston University
Mar 2026	Judge, Harvard College High School Ethics Bowl
Feb 2026	Co-Organizer (with Christopher Benzenberg), SGIR Session "Kant's Ethics of Belief", APA Central Division Meeting
Feb 2025	Co-Organizer (with Davide Dalla Rosa), Kant on Language and Cognition Workshop, Goethe-Universität Frankfurt
2021 - 2026	Paper Referee, Boston University Graduate Student Philosophy Conference
2023 - 2024	Alumni & Placement Officer, BU Philosophy Graduate Student Association
May 2023	Co-Organizer (with Giulia Battistoni), "Organism and Life: Herder, Kant, Hegel" Workshop, Boston University
Apr 2023	Co-Organizer, Boston University Graduate Student Philosophy Conference
Nov 2022	Co-Organizer (with Joshua Folkerts), Boston Young Hegelian Workshop
2021 - 2022	International Student Representative, BU Philosophy Graduate Student Association
2018 – 2019	Founding Member and Executive Officer, Philiminality Oxford
2018 – 2019	Committee Member, the Jowett Society, University of Oxford
2018 – 2019	Committee Member, the Ockham Society, University of Oxford
2018	Co-Organizer and Paper Referee, the 22nd Oxford Graduate Philosophy Conference

Language

Chinese (native, incl. Classical Chinese), English (fluent), German (B2), Sanskrit (intermediate reading)

Dissertation Summary

Towards a Hybrid Reading of Kant's Transcendental Idealism

In my dissertation, I propose a novel reading of Kant's transcendental idealism, which I call the hybrid reading. Roughly put, transcendental idealism is the doctrine that the objects we can experience, which Kant calls appearances, are in some way mind-dependent, and that we cannot know how things are in themselves. Current interpretations of this doctrine fall into two main camps. According to metaphysical readings, transcendental idealism amounts to the thesis that reality has a hierarchical structure: things in themselves are what are ultimately real, while appearances are less real. Epistemic readings, by contrast, take this doctrine to merely highlight the fact that there are certain a priori conditions under which alone cognition is possible for us, and that we cannot cognize or know anything about things that do not conform to those conditions.

My hybrid reading steers a middle course between these two camps by combining elements from both. Like metaphysical readers, I believe that Kant's idealism offers a hierarchical picture of reality. More specifically, I argue in agreement with metaphysical readings that appearances and things in themselves are two distinct sets of beings, that Kant is committed to the existence of things in themselves as what grounds appearances, and that Kant takes appearances to depend on us for their existence. I agree with epistemic readers, however, that Kant takes the conditions of human cognition – space, time, and the categories – to be central to how we describe the world. As I read him, Kant believes that any human metaphysical endeavor is subject to the limit of the conditions of our cognition and cannot reach how the world really is from the "God's Eye" point of view. This is because, for Kant, we can only think about uncognizable things in themselves by analogy with objects of possible experience, which means that we can think about nothing independently of the constraint of our forms of cognition. I further argue that, while Kant is committed to the existence of things in themselves, this commitment is not knowledge, but rather a form of belief (Glauben) justified by the interests of our reason. In short, on my reading, Kant's transcendental idealism amounts to a radically anthropocentric metaphysics: it includes both a theory of first-order metaphysics and a meta-metaphysical account of how this metaphysics is constrained by the conditions of our cognition and the interests of our reason.

This dissertation is organized around four questions that are central to the debate between metaphysical and epistemic readers: (1) whether Kant takes appearances and things in themselves to be two distinct sets of beings; (2) whether he regards things in themselves to be ultimately real from the "God's Eye" point of view; (3) whether he allows any knowledge of things in themselves; and (4) whether he takes our empirical objects to be mind-dependent. After surveying how metaphysical and epistemic readers answer these questions, I present my own answers to them in chapters 2 to 5 respectively. In Chapter 2, I show that Kant takes appearances and things in themselves to be two distinct sets of beings by arguing against Henry Allison's view to the contrary. In Chapter 3, I argue against the metaphysical readers' view that things in themselves are how the world ultimately is from the "God's Eye" point of view. Instead, I suggest that they are merely how we think about the mind-independent world underlying appearances, and all our thinking is fundamentally constrained by the forms of our cognition. In Chapter 4, I show that Kant denies that we can have knowledge (Wissen) of the existence of things in themselves, even though he allows us to have practically justified belief, or Glaube, about this. Finally, in chapter 5, I argue that appearances are partially mind-dependent intentional objects of our experience: they depend on us for their form, but their matter is mind-independent.

References

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